
Step Forward on Sponsorships

Building New Revenue Through
Mission-Aligned Partnerships

Presented by:

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Welcome back! Here's our agenda

3-Part Work Session Agenda

01 **The Partnership Approach:** Shift to a Partnership Mindset

02 **Identifying the Right Partners:** Prospecting & Warm Leads

03 **Building the Sponsorship:** Workflow & Scenarios

Q&A and discussion of real-world scenarios encouraged! Drop ideas in the chat!

Partnership approach: comprehensive, mission-aligned, sponsorships

Core concept: Comprehensive campaigns bring in ALL of your audience touchpoints and benefit the creator, the sponsor, and the audience.

Key Characteristics

Mission Aligned

Does the partner organizations share our core values and audience interests?

Relationship-driven

Not transaction and are based on discovery i.e. from listening to prospect needs

Integration

Does the sponsor messaging compliment and feel like an extension of our content?

Today: Identifying the *right* partners

Core concept: *Prospecting for mission-aligned sponsors and approach them without feeling “sale-sy.”*

Value Proposition

Targeted Reach

Amplify their messaging to our niche and engaged audiences on new platforms

Brand Awareness

Align with the important topics & communities we have developed

Thought Leadership

Be a part of the movement - the conversations, reporting and events you are facilitating

Leveraging your network



Core Strategy: Your existing network is the best place to start find mission-aligned partners to add value to current and new projects.

Identifying potential warm leads from your:



Your Supporters

Current subscribers, donors, and those who actively champion your work. Who's in their network? Ask for a referral?



Your Audience

Through your engaged and connected community. Survey the products and services they need and love?



Your Content

Who shows up in the key topics you cover frequently? Where are the “unpaid mentions?” Can you share your brand with them?

Growing your prospecting list



Reminder: Expand beyond corporate sponsorships.

Business Sector: Local/regional companies, service providers, major employers, and new market entrants.

Professional & Advocacy Groups: Business associations, policy organizations, and professional networks.

Institutional Partners: Arts, cultural, sports, and higher education organizations.

Corporate Philanthropy: Private foundations and donor-advised funds.

Government & Public Sector: Local service agencies, development groups and parks/public spaces.

Existing Supporters: Current initiative investors like foundations and philanthropy.

Other ideas?

Explore: Mission-aligned messaging

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Cold calls vs. warm leads



Core Strategy: Personalization is key!

What goes in the email?



1. The Right Contact

Who is the best person to reach out to? Target marketing leads, corporate foundations, or senior leadership to start off strong.



2. The Context Hook

Reference mutual company news, a recent campaign, or a shared upcoming conference to establish immediate relevance.



3. The Primary Ask

Request a casual coffee meetup or a quick call. Keep it light — avoid proposing yet another exhausting virtual meeting.



4. The Second Ask

Always ask: "Who else should I speak with?" to unlock warm referrals and navigate the organization effectively.

Examples: Mission-aligned messaging from your subscribers & supporters

Please tell your friends to [get their OWN subscription](#) to the Austin Politics Newsletter! And if you found this article particularly valuable, you can show your appreciation by [buying me a cup of coffee](#) to fuel further investigation and analysis of city politics.

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Theresa, who mounted a valiant underdog challenge to U.S. Rep. Michael McCaul in 2024, was our own realtor and worked wonders to get our house sold in a challenging market. If you're looking to buy or sell in the Austin area, I can't recommend her highly enough.

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Examples: Inspiration from Project C sites

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Ulrike Langer
May 6, 2020



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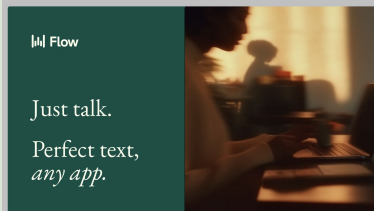
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So that's when I wrote down a simple list: *ten things I wanted to become by the end of the year*.

One of those ten was to become a Lonely Planet contributor.

Shortly after I wrote the list, I saw a call for submissions from Lonely Planet for their annual travel anthology.

Without expecting much, I submitted my nonfiction story, *The Night Is Young*.

Legendary travel editor Don George replied to my submission with an email that opened with this line: "*Dear Yulia, congratulations!*"

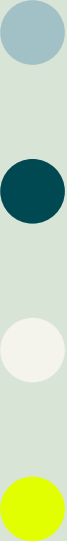
Group discussion: Insight from inspiration audit exercise



Audit 3 content creators or news outlets you admire:

- *What stood out when auditing the 3 creators/outlets you admire?*
- *What “job” is the sponsor solving for?*
- *What is one new tactic or target sponsor you want to try based on this exercise?*

Final Exercise: Develop your Next Three

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1. Internal audit: Leverage all the ways you connect with audiences. Inform your positioning statement.
 2. Inspiration audit: Informs your prospecting list.
 3. **Next Steps: Name Key 3 to tackle following this workshop. These could include creating a prospecting list, preparing a positioning statement, or requesting a new introduction.**

Next session: You landed that meeting!

Now What? Stop Planning, Start Listening

We're solving problems, not pitching products.

Goals

What are the business goals and challenges?

Audiences/s

Which targeted audience/s do they need to reach?

Timing

What are the dates of a campaign?

Budget

Idea of an investment range?

Next Session: Pulling it Together

Building the Sponsorship: *We'll cover proposals, pricing and real-world scenarios to practice.*
